

18, The Situation in Southern India, and the Favorable and Unfavorable Factors for Its Feudalization

The situation in Southern India was markedly different. From the geographical trajectory of the Aryan migration into India, the rise of civilization in Southern India unquestionably lagged behind the North. Culturally, the Dravidian-speaking (达罗毗荼语) peoples of Southern India were monumentally influenced by the Aryans.

However, the social development of Southern India was phenomenally rapid. This was intrinsically because its geographical location positioned it squarely at the epicenter of the Maritime Silk Road. Although geographically segregated from Northern India by formidable mountain ranges, Southern India could seamlessly connect the vast regions from China in the east to East Africa in the west via its coastal ports. As a Chinese person, I heard the tales of the great monks Xuanzang (玄奘) and Yijing (义净) traveling to India to seek Buddhist dharma since childhood; I was always profoundly struck by the astronomical disparity in the time expended, hardships endured, and lethal perils faced between taking the overland route versus the maritime route.

Because Southern India was integrated into international trade to such a staggeringly high degree, commercial factors became a critical variable that fundamentally cannot be ignored. During the 6th century AD, commercial activities played a monumental role in regional societies. Consequently, Southern Indian rulers aggressively favored Buddhism and Jainism—religions highly conducive to commerce (*as their doctrines were fiercely embraced by merchants*).

However, what is exceptionally fascinating is that during the transition from Brahmanism to medieval Hinduism, it was precisely Southern India that played the absolutely decisive role post-first millennium AD. The **Bhakti movement** (虔敬运动 / devotional movement)—characterized by monolatry (单一主神崇拜)—originated and violently expanded within the Tamil region (泰米尔地区) of Southern India. Furthermore, Adi Shankara (商羯罗)—a philosopher occupying a monumental position in the history of Hinduism—was born in the southwestern state of Kerala. (*Regardless of how opaque his personal biography remains, the emergence of a monastic system [修道院体系] in Southern India during this era is historically indisputable*).

Although it appears bizarre that Southern India—which retained vastly more non-Aryan culture—would spearhead revolutionary changes ahead of Northern India (where Brahmanism had been entrenched for eons), upon closer scrutiny, it is not the least bit mysterious.

When an ideology has evolved and calcified in a specific region for too long, it intrinsically becomes detrimental to adapting to radical changes. It is akin to how it is fundamentally unimaginable that the Protestant Reformation, which ignited in late medieval Europe, could have conceivably originated in Italy right under the Pope's nose. The ideological grip of Brahmanism in Southern India was relatively relaxed, and a vastly greater proportion of non-Aryan culture was preserved. Not to mention that maritime commerce perpetually imported diverse cultures and philosophies from overseas. **It is entirely natural that revolutionary mutations first germinate in relatively pluralistic environments.**

Concurrently, the structure of the caste system in Southern India was significantly more flexible (*or rather, simpler*). Burton Stein notes in *A History of India* that during the transition from the classical to the medieval era, people in Southern India did not strictly avoid consanguineous marriage, and

even trended toward cross-cousin marriages; in some regions, there were simply only two explicit castes. This flexibility was phenomenally advantageous for the internal reformation of Hinduism.

However, although the **feudalization** (封建化) of Southern India might not have commenced much later than in the North (*potentially developing as early as the 7th or 8th century*)—and ideological shifts, such as the decline of Buddhism and Jainism alongside some Southern rulers even taking pride in violently persecuting Jains, certainly corroborate this—the **feudalization process in Southern India was equally agonizingly unsmooth**. And this was true despite the region tenaciously and successfully repelling Muslim invasions for a very long time.

The topography of Southern India was vastly more complex and volatile, and its developmental timeline was later than the North's. Consequently, its forests and mountainous terrains harbored **communities** (社群) that constituted a phenomenally higher percentage of the total population. Therefore, its **"internal frontiers"** (内部边疆) were exponentially more massive.

Furthermore, commerce played a role here somewhat analogous to its function in the Byzantine Empire. Beginning in the 9th century, massive merchant guilds (商业行会) materialized across Southern India; merchants left a ubiquitous trail of inscriptions across the entire southern subcontinent. The sheer multitude and vitality of these commercial organizations during the early Middle Ages (*referring here to the European chronology of the Middle Ages*) is breathtaking, even when compared to Europe.

Yet, a hyper-prosperous foreign trade is absolutely not guaranteed to be advantageous for the formation of a feudal system. As Burton Stein astutely observed: while the decay of urban civilization undeniably occurred during India's transition from the classical to the medieval period, the magnitude of this decay was nowhere near comparable to the catastrophic urban collapse witnessed in Europe. Regarding Northern India, urban decay was likely quite pronounced during the early Middle Ages; however, in Southern India, it was highly likely imperceptible. One might even conclude that Southern India virtually skipped this phase, with its cities relentlessly developing. **This was unquestionably the consequence of a robust commodity economy** (商品经济) **forcefully hedging against the natural economy** (自然经济).

For Southern Indian regimes, the strategic imperative of foreign trade was likely far more visceral than for traditional commercial states. Following the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate (德里苏丹国) in the North, Southern India palpably felt the crushing pressure exerted by northern Muslim regimes. Yet, in military competition, the South easily fell into a lethal disadvantage due to a chronic shortage of warhorses. Therefore, importing horses—and later, firearms—via coastal ports mutated into a desperate measure for sheer survival, no longer driven merely by profit.

Consequently, spanning from the 7th to the 14th century, Southern Indian society remained locked in a highly hybridized morphology: highly developed commercial metropolises and massive tribal populations residing in deep forests frequently coexisted within the exact same region, nominally subjugated under a single ruler.

The role played by Hindu temples (印度教寺庙) in socio-economic life was astronomically more vital than in Northern India. These temples simultaneously monopolized vast tracts of land and possessed the absolute capacity to dictate local economies—a phenomenon supposedly persisting even today.

This extraordinarily explosive proliferation of religion highly likely reflected a terrifying reality: **state power was still being violently blocked outside the frontiers by countless autonomous communities, petty kingdoms, and tribal chieftains.** The core zones genuinely controlled by massive states remained exceptionally limited. Religion violently rushed in to fill the colossal vacuum left by the weakness of secular power in terms of regional political, economic, and cultural integration.

This ought to be a universal iron law: **Whenever geographical environments cripple secular power's capacity to penetrate the grassroots, religion and religious organizations inevitably mutate into formidable leviathans to orchestrate and organize social life.** This dynamic is exceptionally glaring in Inner Asia. Given that Southern India sat squarely at the absolute fulcrum of Eurasian maritime trade, the gross volume of economic circulation across the region was inevitably astronomical. Coupled with Southern India's massive population, it was entirely natural for temples to aggressively participate in economic activities on a massive scale.

Therefore, it is genuinely exceedingly difficult to definitively categorize which Southern Indian regime belonged to the **classical era (classical period/古典时代)** and which was strictly a **feudal** regime; the social mutations here were agonizingly gradual.

At its absolute zenith, the Chola Dynasty (朱罗王朝) functioned far more like a **classical empire** (古典帝国): hereditary lords vanished from historical records, and the administrative bureaucracy vastly expanded (*though the territories under direct imperial jurisdiction remained highly likely quite limited*). The empire commanded formidable armies and extensive garrisons, launched unprecedented and unparalleled maritime expeditions into Southeast Asia, and constructed myriad massive public architectural works and canals domestically.

However, by the time the Vijayanagara Empire (毗奢耶那迦罗帝国) ruled Southern India, the **feudal system** was already glaringly conspicuous. Tenancy relations dominated the mainstream, and the emperors actively incentivized local chieftains to exchange military service for lucrative land rights. During the empire's later period, the Emperor Krishnadevaraya ruthlessly swept away the autonomous chiefdoms (酋邦) within the empire's core ruling zones to enforce direct rule (*ensuring that, at the very least, there were no "internal frontiers" lingering near the capital*). Concurrently, he deliberately distributed fiefdoms to vassals (封建封臣) in newly conquered frontiers. Through these vassals, he indirectly fortified control over grassroots autonomous entities. Ultimately, the legitimacy of these grassroots rulers was tethered directly to the emperor.

Although delayed, this was a monumentally significant leap. In previous Southern Indian dynasties, various autonomous chiefdoms and petty kingdoms might have nominally paid homage to a mighty monarch, but their political legitimacy fundamentally did not derive from any superior ruler; rather, it was deeply rooted in the traditional identitarian recognition of their own **communities** (社群).

Consequently, we observe a second glaringly distinct characteristic in the history of Southern India: **from antiquity to the early modern era, this specific region fundamentally did not experience a conspicuous phase of decaying state power.** Arguably, the **infrastructural power** of successive regimes actually *increased* over time.

This is a point I am desperate to emphasize. Many characteristics that people today associate with the so-called **feudal society** (封建社会) are, in the final analysis, merely phenomena generated by the "transition" from a **classical society** (古典社会) to a **feudal society**, rather than constituting the

intrinsic essence of a *feudal society* itself. If a typical *classical society* fundamentally never existed prior to **feudalization**, there is absolutely zero reason to assume these characteristics would manifest explicitly. This perfectly explains why Southern India could exhibit such a seemingly bizarre paradox: **"The more feudal it became, the more centralized it grew."**

Undoubtedly, the genesis of these two characteristics in Southern India stemmed directly from the hyper-complexity of Southern Indian society itself (*excessively vast "internal frontiers" and an overabundance of dispersed communities*), coupled with the ferocious impact of overseas trade.

However, this exact illusion of "relentless linear progress" (一路进步) harbors colossal deceptiveness. It is precisely akin to the dazzling prosperity and advancement paraded by the Tang and Song Empires during the early phases of their **bureaucratic restoration** (官僚制度复辟).

Without genuinely undergoing a complete and thoroughly exhaustive feudal process, the social organizations and social consciousness generated by that precise process simply cannot spontaneously materialize out of thin air.

It is undeniably true that when European power abruptly materialized across the globe in the 16th century, driven by the dawn of the world market and rapid technological diffusion, virtually every single non-Western regime—from the Eastern Mediterranean (Ottomans) to Iran, India, and China—experienced a massive inflation of state power. An intoxicating illusion of a booming "Golden Age" (繁荣盛世) was ubiquitous.

Yet, apart from Japan, absolutely no nation across the entire Afro-Asian expanse genuinely embarked upon the pathway to modernization. One could definitively argue that, outside of sheer population and gross economic output, these regions completely lacked the necessary "third prerequisite" (i.e., social reorganization). Regardless of what developmental plateau these nations had previously achieved, their era of relatively independent organic societal evolution was now crashing to an end. Even if their **feudalization** was only halfway complete, it was now fundamentally impossible to finish the second half of the journey according to a normalized historical trajectory.

The overwhelming majority of nations globally were violently forced to reckon with exactly *how* they would approach modern civilization after their organic historical progression had been savagely amputated by Western impact.

However, looking specifically at India—the protagonist of these recent paragraphs—I do not actually belittle this nation as many contemporary observers do. This is because, although India's historical progression was perpetually retarded by myriad insurmountable factors that obstructed its **feudalization** process, **it ultimately never birthed a phenomenally destructive, dangerous institutional apparatus like China's.**

Furthermore, unlike in China, the importation of modern civilizational achievements has generally exerted an *eliminative* effect on the archaic elements that historically choked India's development. For instance, no matter how frequently the concept of the **"community"** (社群) is resurrected in the political sloganing of modern Indians, it is fundamentally impossible for it to function as the primary participating unit in politics as it did in antiquity. Similarly, modern technology will inevitably liquidate the state's "internal frontiers."

Conversely, a pathologically deformed bureaucratic system can undeniably weaponize modern technology to exponentially fortify its own dictatorial rule and inflict infinitely greater catastrophes.

This terrifying reality was already comprehensively and irrefutably proven by the Soviet Union and its myriad satellites during the 20th century.

18，南印度的情况，以及其封建化的有利因素与不利因素

南印度的情况有所不同，从雅利安人进入印度的地理形势来讲，南印度的文明兴起比北印度肯定是要晚一些，南印度说达罗毗荼语的民族在文化上受到雅利安人的极大影响。不过南印度的社会发展却非常迅速，原因在于印度的地理位置处在海上丝绸之路的正中间，南印度虽然和北印度在地理上被崇山峻岭相隔，但是却可以通过沿岸的港口连接东到中国，西到东非的广大区域。作为中国人，我很小就听过玄奘法师和义净法师两人前往印度求取佛法的故事，并且对于他们分别走陆路和海路所付出的时间和辛劳，遭到的危险相距如此之大感到印象深刻。南印度接入国际贸易的程度如此之高，因此商业因素就成为一个不得不考虑的关键项。在六世纪的时候商业活动在地区社会中扮演了重要角色，因而南印度统治者非常青睐于有利于商业的（因为其教义受商人欢迎）的佛教和耆那教。不过非常有趣的是，在婆罗门教向中世纪印度教转变的过程中，反而是南印度在公元第一个千纪后起决定性作用。以单一主神崇拜为特征的虔诚运动（Bhakti）起源并壮大于南印度的泰米尔地区，在印度教历史上占有重要地位的哲学家商羯罗出生在西南方的喀拉拉邦（不管他本人的生平如何模糊，但是南印度出现修道院体系是可靠的）。

虽然看起来南印度保留了更多非雅利安文化，先于婆罗门教在印度长期盘踞的北印度发生变革很奇怪，但仔细一想就会发现一点半点不神秘。一种意识形态在某个地区发展的时间太久对于适应变革原本就是坏事，就好比人们很难想象中世纪晚期从欧洲开始的宗教改革首先发生在意大利，教皇眼皮子底下一样。南印度婆罗门教意识形态相对宽松，非雅利安文化保留下来的更多，更别说商业活动一样从海外带来了不同的文化和思想，变革首先出现在相对多元的环境中是正常的。同时，南印度种姓制度的结构更加灵活（或者说更加简单，伯顿斯坦在《印度文明史》中就有提到在从古典时代迈向中世纪的时候，南印度人们不严格避免近亲结婚，甚至倾向于表亲婚姻，一些地方干脆只有两个明显的种姓），这对于印度教的改革也是有利的。

然而虽然南印度的封建化可能并不比北印度晚多久展开（或许从七、八世纪开始就有所发展），意识形态的变化也支持这一点，佛教和耆那教开始衰落，一些南印度统治者甚至以迫害耆那教徒为荣。但是南印度的封建化进程一样不顺利，哪怕这里在很长时间内都顽强抵制住了穆斯林侵略。南印度的地貌更加复杂多变，从开发的时间上比北印度要晚，因此在森林山地中容纳了占总人口比例更高的社群，“内部边疆”因此更为庞大。商业也在这里起到了某种程度和对拜占庭相似的作用，从九世纪开始商业行会出现在南印度，商人们在整个次大陆南部留下铭文，在中世纪早期（这里是指欧洲人界定的中世纪）如此众多活跃的商业组织即使与欧洲相比也是令人赞叹的。然而外贸繁荣对于封建制度的形成不一定是一件有利的事情，就像伯顿斯坦也注意到，在印度从古典时期向中世纪过渡时，城市文明的衰退确实也出现了，但是其程度远远不能和欧洲的情况相比。就北印度的情况而言，城市衰退应当在中世纪早期比较明显，但是在南印度就很可能难以观测，甚至人们会发现南印度可能没有经历这个阶段，它的城市一直在发展，这无疑是商品经济对于自然经济进行有力对冲的后果。

对于南印度政权来说，对外贸易的战略意义可能比传统上那些商业国家更大。从德里苏丹国在北方建立开始，南印度已经明显感受到了北方穆斯林政权施加的压力，但是在军事竞争中因为马匹的缺少又很容易陷入劣势，通过沿海港口进口马匹还有后来的火枪已经是保命的举措，而不仅仅是因为利润了。因此从7到14世纪间，南印度社会一直处于一种高度混合的形态，发达的商业城市和森林中的部落大量处于同一个地区，名义上从属于一个统治者。印度教寺庙在社会经济生活中扮演的角色远比北印度更为重要，同时占有了大量的土地，完全有能力左右地方经济，据说在今天也是如此。宗教的这种异乎寻常的蓬勃

发展，很有可能反映了国家权力仍然被不计其数的自治社群、小王国和酋长拦在封疆之外，一个大国的核心区域依然极为有限，宗教填补了世俗权力在区域的政治，经济，文化联系和整合作用上的薄弱。这应当是普遍性的规律，受自然地理环境影响世俗权力难以深入地方时，宗教和宗教组织就会变得强大起到组织社会生活的作用，这一点在亚洲内陆比较明显。南印度既然处于整个欧亚大陆贸易的枢纽位置，整个区域的经济流通总额必然很大，再加上南印度本身人口也不少，寺庙大量参与到经济活动中来就十分正常了。

因此人们确实很难说南印度哪个政权属于古典政权，哪个就一定是封建政权，这里的社会变化非常渐进。朱罗王朝（Chola）在鼎盛时更像一个古典帝国，世袭领主从历史记录中消失，行政官僚扩大（不过恐怕帝国直辖的范围还是很有限）。帝国拥有强大的军队和广泛的驻军，对于东南亚发起了空前绝后的远征，在国内修建了许多大型公共建筑和运河。但是等到毗奢耶那迦罗帝国（Vijayanagara）统治南印度的时候，封建制度就已经十分明显了，租佃关系占据主流，皇帝鼓励酋长们用军事服役换取丰厚的土地权利。帝国后期的皇帝 Krishnadevaraya 坚决扫荡帝国统治核心区域的酋邦以进行直接统治（这样至少离首都很近的地方没有内部边疆了），同时有意识地在征服的边疆分封封臣，并通过这些封臣间接加强了对基层自治实体的控制，基层统治者的合法性最终将来源于皇帝。这是虽然晚但是有意义的一步，之前的南印度王朝中各个自治的酋邦和小王国可能在名义上尊奉一个强大的君王，但是其合法性毕竟不来自任何上级统治者，而是根植于社群的传统认同。

因此我们看到的南印度历史上第二个显著特征，那就是从古代到近代，这个地区并没有经过一个明显的国家权力衰退的阶段，历代政权的基础性权力可以说是随时间增强的。这是我非常想强调的事，人们今天看到的所谓封建社会的很多特点，归根到底是一种从古典社会到封建社会发生的“变化”而不是封建社会的本质。如果封建化之前根本就不存在典型的古典社会，那就没有理由认为这些特点会体现得十分明显，就好比南印度可能出现“越封建越中央集权”如此看似奇怪的现象一样。

南印度的两个特征的产生毫无疑问来自南印度社会本身的复杂性（内部边疆太过广大，分散的社群太多）和海外贸易的强烈影响。可就是这样的“一路进步”具有很大的迷惑性，就如同唐帝国和宋帝国在官僚复辟前期所显示出的繁荣和先进一样。没有经历过完整的、彻底的封建进程，那么这个过程所产生的社会组织和社会意识就没办法自己冒出来。诚然当欧洲人的力量于 16 世纪出现在世界各地时，得益于世界市场的出现和技术扩散，从东地中海（奥斯曼）到伊朗到印度到中国，简直没有哪一个非西方政权没有出现国家权力扩大的情况，到处都是繁荣的盛世景象。除了日本，在整个亚非地区谁也没有真正走上现代化的道路，可以说在人口和经济总量以外，这些地方就不具备第三个条件了。这些国家之前发展到哪个水平，现在其社会相对独立的发展时期将要走到尽头，即使封建化走到一半，也不可能再像正常历史进程一样再把后半段走完。全世界绝大多数国家都不得不考虑在其正常历史进程被西方的影响打断之后将以何种方式接近现代文明。不过具体到这几段的主角印度，我倒不像很多观察者一样看轻这个国家，因为印度在历史上虽然因为各种难以对抗的因素在封建化过程中不断受到阻碍导致历史进程被拖慢了，但是毕竟没有出现中国这么危险的破坏性的体制。而且与中国不同，现代文明成果的传入对于曾经阻碍印度历史发展的事物总体来看是起到了淘汰的作用，例如社群这个概念现在无论再怎么出现在印度人的政治口号中，它都不可能像以前一样作为政治的主要参与单位出现了，同样现代技术也会扫清国家的内部边疆。但是畸形的官僚制度的确可以用现代技术来巩固其统治并造成更大危害，这一点在 20 世纪已经被苏联及其仆从广泛证明了。